

Fabley Tales WILL DEWGRAVE

Praise for *Fabley Tales*:

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Content Warning: Reader discretion is mandated.

Dedicated to the characters in stories, may they find happy endings after we stop reading, wherever we have left them.

Writing isn't safe. The following tales were found by a squirrel guerrilla unit secluded in an abandoned raccoon burrow. The text was positioned at the center of a heptagram drawn on the burrow's foundation, with a panther's likeness on the teal cover. The reader is advised against reading this work during the blue blood moon, especially backwards, as there are questions which it can be dangerous to answer. The soat doesn't wonder about water's wetness when there is kelp close. This may be wisdom.

'Three Little Writers' Once upon a time there were three little writers. They were well-educated and widely-respected for their work, but each was struggling to make enough to feed themselves, as is the way with writing. The president of a local but prestigious university announced the instigation of a tenure position there, but there was only one position available to fill.

Each of the writers assembled their best stories, each doing their best to convince the selection committee of the value of their writing. They each thought long and hard about the best manner of demonstrating their skills, and ultimately, each approached the challenge in their own manner.

The first little writer prepared a story entirely from his imagination. It was a new story, and well-constructed, but it was utterly divorced from reality, and the selection committee found the flights of fancy too extreme. They huffed and puffed and determined the first little writer could be a sessional instructor, at best.

The second little writer prepared a story based on one he'd heard before. He modified details, added a subplot, and made the story his own as best he could, but it was still rather like the original, and the selection committee found they were not only reminded of the original, but could scarcely tell the difference between the versions. They huffed and puffed and decided the second little writer might lead a workshop, time permitting.

The third little writer, seeing the fate of the first two, wondered how he might prove the victor and claim tenure. He told the story of his life, knowing that the selection committee would not be familiar with it, but augmented the stakes, and rendered the characters mythological and fabulist. The selection committee

huffed and puffed, but could not claim to have heard the story before, nor could they suggest it too fantastic, possessed, as it was, of concrete elements.

The committee ultimately provided tenure to the third little writer, who was kind enough to allow the other two writers to act as a sessional instructor, and a workshop leader, respectively. This was enough that the other two writers could keep the panther from the door, but they were never as contented as the tenured third.

‘The Boy Who Cried Panther’ There once was a village tucked away in a misty mountain range. The inhabitants of the village were shepherds, keeping flocks of sheep which they took onto the verdant slopes to graze on the flora there. This village was a tight-knit community, which relied upon itself to monitor threats to its livelihood.

There was a boy in the village, scarcely beyond his swaddling clothes, whose parents had left him there in his infancy. He could not remember their faces, and found himself often watching other families as they played and ate together. The boy’s uncle was a kind but busy man, who hadn’t the time to attend to anything beyond the boy’s material needs.

And so, while the boy was cared for in terms of his physicality, eating as he pleased and sleeping with a roof over his head, something lacked from his life. His lack of parenting prevented his making inroads to connecting with the other children socially, and his only friends were the bleating sheep he tended when it was his turn to do so.

Isolated as the village was, they had built a large fence around the settlement to prevent predators gaining access, but there was no pasture within the fence, and the sheep required leading out beyond the confines of protection in order to feed. There was one creature whom the villagers feared beyond all else for its power and cunning, and it was a cardinal sin to mention the creature, save in the most dire of need.

One day, while out on the verdant slopes, the boy was keeping a watchful eye on the sheep. His uncle had left him his breakfast out that morning, which he’d eaten in solitary silence, much as he’d eaten his dinner the night previous. The boy was imagining himself as head shepherd of the village, with all the attendant company that would come with such an elevated position. He stuck his chest out with pride at the simulated change in his prospects.

A shadow moved in the distance. It might have been a cloud passing overhead. It might have been something else. The boy was taking no chances, and turned his head towards the village. “Panther!” He shouted. “Panther!” The effect was instantaneous. The men immediately ran to him, armed and jittery, and helped him to seclude the herd back within the walls of the village. But there was no panther. The shadow had been a cloud, and now the work which had been left required even more effort to get done.

The villagers were immensely displeased, and castigated the boy for his folly.

He was relieved of his work for the day, and instead kept locked in his room at home, where he wept bitter tears and turned his imagination to the revenge he would take at this injustice. He was not permitted to leave his room until the next day, when his uncle summarily unlocked the door, presented the boy his breakfast, and left him to eat and think further on his mistakes.

It was several weeks before the boy was entrusted with the flock once more. He was left with his bleating charges, and where once he had fantasized of leading the village as a wise and equanimous leader, now he envisioned the opportunity such advancement would provide to punish his peers, who he felt had done him a rude injustice.

A shadow moved in the distance. It might have been a bear in the woods. It might have been something else. The boy hesitated a moment, but then, with grim awareness of what it was he did, he let loose the same cry. "Panther!" He yelled as loudly as his lungs could bear. "Panther!"

Once more the villagers sprang into action, secluding the sheep in safety and dropping their efforts, only to find that there was no panther, and that the boy had once again impeded their earnest efforts with his cries. The villagers, now ruing the boy, once more locked him in his room, and there he remained for two days, with his uncle passing him his food, and not saying a word to him in so-doing.

It was many months before the boy was permitted to watch the flock once more, but the villagers were not hard of heart, believing that the boy needed to learn the manners of the shepherds, and that further punishment would only hurt him when the lesson, they felt, had been learned.

The boy, for his part, now did not imagine anything. He stood among the sheep and allowed his mind to drift as he'd taught it to in the locked room. The sheep, bleating and chewing determinedly, were more present in the moment than he. When the first few drops of rain began to shower upon him, he hardly registered them.

A shadow moved in the distance. It might have been a panther. It might have been two. The boy, divorced as he was from reality, reacted instinctively to the lithe cat's approach. Once more he cried. "Panther!" There was no response. The villagers recognized his voice but, remembering the previous precedent set by the boy, stayed where they were, and said to themselves that this would be the last time the boy tended to the sheep.

They didn't know how right they were, and when the sheep and boy failed to return that night, a search party was sent out into the dusk. All that could be found of the boy or his flock were stains left on the misty mountain slopes, and the echoing cries of "Panther!" fading into the night.

'Little Teal Riding Hood' There once was a young lady, wholly naive to many of life's intricacies, and all the more adored by those close to her for her innocence. She lived with her mother, who tended to her every want, and educated her

as best she was able. One year, for the young lady's thirteenth birthday, her mother made her a hooded cape, in the most bright and becoming shade of teal, which the young lady thereafter nigh-refused to remove save under duress.

It was thus that she came to be known as Little Teal Riding Hood, and all the denizens of the forest were always made easy by her presence, as she was often to be seen skipping down trails while singing jaunty shanties she'd learned from her father, prior to his passing. The lumberjacks would regularly hail her, the crows watched over her to ensure she was content wheresoever she wandered, the raccoons would chatter all the more gaily for having her at hand, and the squirrels regularly included her in their plans for large-scale societal upheaval, which was an ongoing concern of theirs.

One day, as Little Teal Riding Hood was busy preparing herself breakfast, her mother came to speak with her. "Your grandmother is ill, Little Teal Riding Hood, and I must ask you to deliver her this hamper of cakes, various over-the-counter decongestant medications, and a rubber duck to her, as I have booked into an introductory pole-dance class, and would be loath to miss it." So saying, she provided Little Teal Riding Hood with the hamper, and made to leave for her exotic dance class.

Pausing as she was about to leave the cabin, Little Teal Riding Hood's mother turned back and issued a word of warning. "And Little Teal Riding Hood, no matter what you do, do not stray from the path, and beware the Huge Hungry Panther who's been seen in the woods." Little Teal Riding Hood assured her mother that she would be careful, and heed her words, so her mother left.

Soon Little Teal Riding Hood was travelling through the woods, along the well-demarcated path that had been built by the woodsmen. This path stretched all the way from the mountain range in the west, all the way to the river which bordered the forest in the east, and beyond which lay Little Teal Riding Hood knew not what; probably dragons.

Skipping along the path and singing merrily, Little Teal Riding Hood failed to notice the silence which now otherwise surrounded her. The crows weren't cawing. The raccoons failed to chatter, the squirrels must have been elsewhere, earnestly plotting. All that could be heard, beside Little Teal Riding Hood's mellow baritone, was the murmur of leaves in the wind.

A shadow moved between the tree trunks, the lofty arbor shivering as beneath the crowns of the trees a sable shape nipped to and fro, hither and yon, keeping a close eye on Little Teal Riding Hood. It cut ahead of the skipping girl, and positioned itself on a bough overhanging the path. A low, resonant purr of satisfaction escape the Huge Hungry Panther, as she awaited Little Teal Riding Hood's arrival.

Soon Little Teal Riding Hood was within pouncing distance of the Huge Hungry Panther, but suddenly stopped just out of range of the cat's ferociously sharp claws. The purr stopped, and Little Teal Riding Hood looked up into the large

green eyes, which never blinked. Momentarily mesmerized, she ceased singing the song of never abandoning someone, and instead asked of the Huge Hungry Panther: “Say, you’re not the Huge Hungry Panther are you?”

“Certainly not.” The Huge Hungry Panther did her best to hide her disappointment in Little Teal Riding Hood’s being beyond her ambush. While she was sure of being able to chase down and eat Little Teal Riding Hood, were it to come down to it, the Huge Hungry Panther was also keenly aware that the local woodsmen had been offering jiu-jitsu lessons to the inhabitants of the forest in preparation for just such a situation as this. While the Huge Hungry Panther knew she could eat Little Teal Riding Hood, she hoped to possess herself of a more conducive opportunity of finishing her quarry.

“It’s just you are very large; you are a panther; and I can hear your stomach growling from here.” Said Little Teal Riding Hood, not one to be taken in by such evident falsehood. Little Teal Riding Hood took a step back, further out of range of the cat. The Huge Hungry Panther’s tail twitched back and forth, swishing the forest air.

“The Huge Hungry Panther is my brother,” said the Huge Hungry Panther. “I’m the Small Sedate Panther.” The Huge Hungry Panther’s stomach chose that moment to growl voraciously, which she covered up with a polite cough. Little Teal Riding Hood’s fears were, albeit momentarily, assuaged.

“Well that’s alright then,” Little Teal Riding Hood said. “I’m just off to visit my grandmother over on the other side of the forest in her cottage, which is hidden beneath the overhang of a small cliff, tucked away in a ravine.” The tail flicked with feigned indifference to this information, as the Huge Hungry Panther considered that she might be able to eat two people today, rather than the one she’d been banking on.

The Huge Hungry Panther thought that now, perhaps, she could make an end of Little Teal Riding Hood, as she knew where to find the grandmother, but then thought better of it. The Huge Hungry Panther realized that if Little Teal Riding Hood could be traumatized and shocked, then the cortisol running through her would stimulate the Huge Hungry Panther, and provide a buzz akin to a stimulant to the large cat.

“Is that so? And I imagine that you’ve got plenty of goodies there to make sure she’s happy and-“ another stomach growl covered by another coughing fit, “-ahem pardon me; happy and cared for,” the Huge Hungry Panther finished.

Little Teal Riding Hood looked sympathetically at the Huge Hungry Panther. “Would you like some over-the-counter decongestant medication? I have some here for Grandmother, but I’m sure she can’t need all of it. Please, I insist you have some.” So-saying she proffered a small bottle to the Huge Hungry Panther, who eyed it warily.

“Are you positive it’s safe for feline consumption?” The Huge Hungry Panther asked Little Teal Riding Hood. “I would hate to upset my delicate stomach.”

But upon hearing that it was certainly safe for all mammals, and actually being possessed of a minor rheumatism, the Huge Hungry Panther willingly took the bottle being proffered, being careful to retract her claws so that Little Teal Riding Hood wouldn't suspect her peril.

The Huge Hungry Panther downed the bottle in a swig, and thanked Little Teal Riding Hood, as already she felt a warmth spreading through her chest. "In return for your kindness, young lady, I will tell you of a small burrow, not far from here, where a family of raccoons has had pups just a few days prior. Go visit them, and revel in the cuteness of the raccoon pups, your grandmother will be none the wiser."

Little Teal Riding Hood remembered her mother's warning never to stray from the path, but the thought of freshly yipping raccoon pups was enough to convince her. Furthermore, she thought, if this panther hasn't eaten those pups or their parents, that demonstrates the panther's warmheartedness. Having reasoned with herself, and not realizing that raccoons are far cleverer than panthers, and that the Huge Hungry Panther was no match for raccoons had she tried to eat them, Little Teal Riding Hood left the path in the direction the Huge Hungry Panther had indicated.

The Huge Hungry Panther, meanwhile, padded quickly in the direction that Little Teal Riding Hood had told the cat that the grandmother lived. Soon, nestled almost imperceptibly among the foliage, the cabin appeared, and the Huge Hungry Panther descended upon it. The grandmother was wholly unaware that the Huge Hungry Panther knew where she lived, and thought that all knocks at the door would emanate from safe individuals. Thus, she was eaten.

The Huge Hungry Panther was soon dressed in the grandmother's clothes, and lying in the grandmother's bed, awaiting Little Teal Riding Hood's arrival. However, something funny was happening inside her. There was a spreading warmth which had very little to do with the old woman, still squirming, in the panther's stomach, and might have had a lot to do with the over-the-counter decongestant which was, by now, decongesting, among other effects. The Huge Hungry and now eminently woozy Panther soon fell asleep.

Meanwhile, yonder over hill and dale, Little Teal Riding Hood was frolicking with the raccoon pups, but the sun was beginning to cast longer shadows, and she realized she needed to make haste, or risk being out in the forest at night, and alone. The raccoon, however, was keen to impress something on Little Teal Riding Hood: "The Huge Hungry Panther was undoubtedly the one you encountered in the woods. She may now be sleepy, considering how much is left in that bottle. Make haste, and you may pass unharmed to your grandmother's.

Little Teal Riding Hood now wasted no time and hastened to her grandmother's hidden cottage. There, she knocked, but upon hearing no reply, and finding the door open to a touch, she entered, and found the Huge Hungry Panther passed out and purring slightly as she slept. Not realizing that this was not, in fact,

her grandmother, Little Teal Riding Hood soon set about trying to wake her, and eventually prevailed, albeit to a limited degree.

The Huge Hungry Panther woke momentarily and yawned. “My, grandmother, what big teeth you have,” said Little Teal Riding Hood, who was earnestly perplexed as to how her grandmother had grown so swarthy and hirsute since she’d last seen her, to say nothing of the absence of incisors.

“All the better to...” and the Huge Hungry Panther suddenly found the warmth had spread too far, and projectile-vomited the grandmother and the over-the-counter decongestant across the cottage. The grandmother, who was in several pieces but still recognizably Little Teal Riding Hood’s grandmother, flopped about the floor and made a ghastly sound, which was enough to alert the raccoon, who came running.

The raccoon was able to subdue the now-retching Huge Hungry Panther, and set about preparing its carcass for the raccoon pups, who were near at hand and yipping all the more concertedly for the excitement, and the impending feast. Little Teal Riding Hood wept over her grandmother’s vivisected and half-digested form, but ultimately remembered her manners, and fed the grandmother-bits to the raccoon pups as well.

‘A Rainy Day’ Cole was a charismatic young man. He had many friends in the city where he lived. It was a sunny city, for the most part.

This was for the best as despite Cole’s best efforts, he was at present homeless and itinerant. But this didn’t dampen his spirits, and his friends appreciated this.

The crows were Cole’s friends. He liked their sleek black outfits, and their deep-throated ‘Caw’. He would whistle to them, and leave scraps of food in high-up places he knew they would be found.

The raccoons were Cole’s friends. He liked their big eyes behind their masks, and their efficient recycling system. He would wave at them, and leave out bowls of water for them to wash their food with.

The squirrels were also Cole’s friends. He liked their energy, and their curious games of tag. He would give them a respectfully wide berth, and gently remind them of where their nuts were buried come winter.

One day Cole was out walking, when he happened upon his friend Crow Frank!

‘Hello Crow Frank,’ Cole said, ‘I hope you’ve been keeping well.’

‘Excellently well, Cole,’ returned Crow Frank, ‘and I am caw-rdially pleased to see you this fine sunny day!’

‘Why might that be, Crow Frank?’ Cole asked.

‘Well it just so happens I have found a plastic bag, and I would like you to save it for me, as I have no pockets,’ Crow Frank explained, ‘I would like you to keep

it for me for a rainy day, Cole, so that I can use it to shelter under. If you do this, I will show you an entry to the tunnels under the city, so that you may do the same.'

'Of course, I will gladly keep it for you, Crow Frank,' Cole replied warmly, 'but we will have no rain for ages they say.'

'Just in case, then. Thank you, Cole. Now, if you will excuse me, I must attend to a recently deceased rat in the alley adjacent,' and so saying Crow Frank flew off.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon his friend Raccoon Em!

'Hello Raccoon Em,' Cole said, 'I hope you've been keeping well.'

'Excellently well, Cole,' returned Raccoon Em, 'and I am in-ordure-nately pleased to see you this fine sunny day!'

'Why might that be, Raccoon Em?' Cole asked.

'Well it just so happens I have found a water bottle, and I would like you to save it for me, as I have no pockets,' Raccoon Em explained, 'I would like you to keep it for me for a rainy day, Cole, so that I can use it to drink fresh rain. If you do this, I will give you a water filter I have hidden, so that you can do the same.'

'Of course, I will gladly keep it for you, Raccoon Em,' Cole replied warmly, 'but we will have no rain for ages they say.'

'Just in case, then. Thank you, Cole. Now, if you will excuse me, I must attend to this route before the disposal men do,' and so saying Raccoon Em lolloped off.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon his friend Squirrel Jess!

'Hello Squirrel Jess,' Cole said, 'I hope you've been keeping well.'

'Excellently well, Cole,' returned Squirrel Jess, 'and I am nuttily pleased to see you this fine sunny day!'

'Why might that be, Squirrel Jess?' Cole asked.

'Well it just so happens I have found a small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system, and I would like you to save it for me, as I have no pockets,' Squirrel Jess explained, 'I would like you to keep it for me for a rainy day, Cole, so that I can use it to assault the entrenched powers-that-be. If you do this, I will give you a manifesto, so that you can do the same.'

'Of course, I will gladly keep it for you, Squirrel Jess' Cole replied warmly, 'but we will have no rain for ages they say.'

'Just in case, then. Thank you, Cole. Now, if you will excuse me, I must attend to the further undermining and ultimate toppling of the bourgeoisie,' and so saying Squirrel Jess dashed off.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon a woman struggling to carry her groceries.

‘If only I had a plastic bag,’ the woman said, ‘I would pay dearly for a plastic bag.’

Cole thought to himself that he could always use the money to buy a new plastic bag for Crow Frank, and thus offered the plastic bag he had, and was rewarded handsomely.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon a man struggling to drink from a tap.

‘If only I had a water bottle,’ the man said, ‘I would pay dearly for a water bottle.’

Cole thought to himself that he could always use the money to buy a new water bottle for Raccoon Em, and thus offered the water bottle he had, and was rewarded handsomely.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon a radicalized-militant-uprising struggling to establish a barricaded-bulwark against an incoming wave of military-police.

‘If only we had a small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system,’ the radicalized-militant-uprising said, ‘We would pay dearly for a small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system.’

Cole thought to himself that he could always use the money to buy a new small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system for Squirrel Jess, and thus offered the small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system he had, and was rewarded handsomely.

And off Cole wandered, until he happened upon a cloud. He happened upon a lot of clouds. A crack of thunder split the sky.

For the most part, this was a city without rain. They said it would not rain for ages, and yet despite this (and perhaps even because of it)...

The rain had come.

It came in sheets. It poured. It was a torrential deluge. It soaked.

Naturally, it was accompanied by thunder, lightning, and the sort of bone chilling gales that made you hold onto your teeth as the inundation was flung at you.

Cole heard a ‘Caw,’ and turned to see Crow Frank flapping bedraggled through the airborne rivulets.

‘Cole, the rain has come, please, the plastic bag!’ Crow Frank cried, ‘I will be unsheltered otherwise.’

‘I haven’t got it, Crow Frank,’ Cole replied, ‘Here, have this money.’

‘What good is money to me? I will be swept away!’ Crow Frank was irked, ‘And so will you, I will not show you the tunnels now.’ So saying, he flew off into the squall.

The rain had come.

Cole saw a flash of fur, and turned to see Raccoon Em hopping bedraggled through the airborne rivulets.

‘Cole, the rain has come, please, the water bottle!’ Raccoon Em cried, ‘I will be thirsty otherwise.’

‘I haven’t got it, Raccoon Em,’ Cole replied, ‘Here, have this money.’

‘What good is money to me? I will be parched to death!’ Raccoon Em was stirred, ‘And so will you, I will not give you the water filter now.’ So saying, she lolloped off into the squall.

The rain had come.

Cole saw a wave of the tricolour, and turned to see Squirrel Jess darting bedraggled through the airborne rivulets.

‘Cole, the rain has come, please, the small rocket-propelled-grenade-launcher-system!’ Squirrel Jess cried, ‘I will be unable to lay siege to the halls-of-the-mighty otherwise.’

‘I haven’t got it, Squirrel Jess,’ Cole replied, ‘Here, have this money.’

‘What good is money to me? I will be subdued, suppressed, and executed as an example to my brethren!’ Squirrel Jess was incensed, ‘And so will you, I will not give you the manifesto now.’ So saying, she dashed off into the squall.

And she was right.

‘Conditioneth’ Once there was a prince of a far-off land. He was a kind and gentle prince, and all the kingdom resounded with word of his beauty.

He was beloved by all his subjects, and yet, the prince was unhappy. He was lonely, and unable to find a partner he considered suitable.

There were many people in his kingdom who would have leapt at the opportunity to adorn the prince’s arm and discuss royal matters with him, but nobody of the prince’s own standing.

Now, there lived in a kingdom just south of the prince’s own, a princess. She was a kind and gentle princess, and all her kingdom resounded with word of her beauty.

The prince and her were, as of yet, unacquainted. The prince, however, had heard tell of this princess and thought that here, perhaps, at last, there might be a suitable partner for him.

So the prince travelled to the southern kingdom, and waited upon the princess at her court. There he found that she was every bit as beautiful as the reports told, and as kind and as gentle as could be wished.

He represented his case to the princess, wooing her with all the earnestness and fealty possible. She requited his approaches, but one day, made a request of him.

It was in the height of summer, and due to both kingdoms' excessive consumption of fossil fuels, the heat was more salient than it had been in summers past.

"O Prince, the heat is sweltering, and I can smell the smog wafting across from the industrial district, please install geothermal power so that we can run the air conditioning system without further degradation of our sensitive climate."

So off the prince went, in search of a geothermal power install-man. He wandered far. He wandered wide. He located a geothermal power repair-man and took his card. He wandered on.

Eventually he made it to a raging river, across which lay a fallen log. On the other side of the river was a small strip-mall with a geothermal power retail outlet.

The prince made to cross the bridge, but was met by a throaty call.

"Hey now, this is a toll-log. It costs several pieces of scandium and a couple of pieces of yttrium to pass," spake a troll, lumbering up from the riverside where he had lain concealed beneath a hubcap.

"Oddly specific," quoth the prince. "But very well; I shall return with the rare-earth minerals you have requested."

And so the prince voyaged back from whence he came to a small pocket of land between the princess's kingdom and that of a distantly removed cousin, currently being fought over by proxy forces of each.

The prince first infiltrated the conflict-ridden mines by pretending to be a rock; his court acting skills holding him in excellent stead.

Upon entry to the mines, the prince was able to not only obtain the ore he sought, but also to smelt it by hoodwinking one of the smelters into looking the other way and staying looking that way for the course of close to an hour, during the prince's nimble egress.

And so the prince returned to the troll of the toll-log and submitted the payment so that he could pass along the log, which was slippery and poorly maintained as logs went, but which did ultimately lead to the strip mall.

The parking lot outside was empty, which was hardly surprising given the access route. Once within the geothermal power retail outlet, the prince rung the bell and spake with the service attendant who said that the install-man would be able to visit imminently.

Having become by this point quite faint with exhaustion, the prince booked a dragon and took it back to the princess's court, being so delicate as to drop the dragon off well clear of the main urban centres, and of course tipping the dragon generously, as befits a prince.

Wishing not to be recognized, he concealed his identity by taking on the role of a jester, dressed head-to-foot in motley, regalia brought expressly for the purpose from a small fancy-dress shop.

He was soon led to court, where he set about practicing the most sublime clowning that none were the wiser as to his true identity. Soon, he found himself possessed of the opportunity of getting the princess on her own, and readily seized it.

"But perchance your love does not return," he said to her, as she perspired slightly in the humid air. "Or, if he were to return, what he knew not then hurteth him not either."

Duly convinced, the princess led the prince in disguise away to the royal chambers and there they did things which would haunt them both for the remainder of their existences. The prince was careful never to remove his jester's hat during the proceedings, which prevented the princess discovering his ploy.

The prince then quit the princess's company and changed back into his princely habit, returning just in time to meet the geothermal power install-man.

"Well looks like you've got plenty of access points we'd be able to tap," spake the geothermal power install-man. "You were hoping to hook this up to an air con system?"

"Verily," spake the princess. "For I do melt."

The install-man nodded his assent, and soon was busily setting about the installation. The prince called a dragon to take him back to the strip mall, in lieu of a tip. The prince tipped the dragon.

And thusly was the court chilled, but the prince's heart rested ill at ease. In truth, he found himself questioning whether his relationship with the princess was truly predicated on mutual affection, or whether she'd simply been sweaty. If it were predicated on providing such material comforts, he considered that he might have gotten a better deal.

Further muddying the moat was the matter of their early joys, which neither had yet broached the topic of with the other. The prince knew what had happened, but the princess did not know of his knowledge, and that ate at him.

And so he bethought himself of the wisest counsel he had recourse to, and sought out the toll-log troll once more, who had convinced him of his wisdom when he demonstrated how to stockpile military-grade elements to be used in the forthcoming clean energy transition.

“The princess be’st as usurious as a loanshark, goodly prince,” quoth the troll. “Tis true am sure, but true tis also that she be’st a freak, and a princess to boot. Perhaps there are people worth paying for.”

“As to the early encounter,” the troll mulled while masticating a plastic straw picked up from the shoreline. “Bethink thee lucky that thou wert able to obtain such privileged access.”

And so the prince betook himself back to his betrothed and bore the belief that beautiful as he was, it was the material comforts he gave that brought him his beloved. This resulted in a good deal of animosity, and ultimately the princess was secluded to a lonely tower, where no jesters might visit her.

The prince would visit her daily, with the express reason being to ensure her wellness and provide company, but which was really to ensure she’d not escaped, and to remind her what he’d bought.

And so there unified the kingdoms in a far off land. They were ruled by a kind and gentle king and queen, and the whole tower resounded with the bays of their beautiful bond.

‘Crunch’ It was late at night as the man lay in his bed, drifting between a light doze and liminal dreams which blended oddly with reality, referencing his preoccupations and the day’s events. All of a sudden, he heard the key in the lock. He sat bolt upright, afraid for his life and tingling with anxiety. Who could that be?

Two women burst into his room. They were masked, in black technical gear. One carried a handgun, which she held aimed towards the floor, keeping watch on the door they’d entered through as the other approached the pyjama-clad form which had secluded itself as far away in the corner of the bed as was possible.

“We’re here at last,” said the woman who had approached the bed, as the woman by the door made frantic motions for them to hurry up. “It’s time for you to come with us, we need to go now. There is no time to explain. This is the sign you have been waiting for. Follow closely, and it will all be okay.”

The man, now fully awake and running through the options in his mind, was terrified, but also intrigued. He’d always known he was different. He’d always known he was destined for a more adrenaline-rich path. Here was the evidence at last. “How do I know I can trust you?” he asked.

“You don’t,” was the warm and comforting reply from the woman by the door. “Come with us or else you will suffer the consequences. We don’t have time for this, come on!” And so she dashed out the door, and the other woman turned back to look at the man and grabbed his arm. “Time to go!” she cried, and pulled him out of the door as well. He did not resist.

Upon the landing, the apartment building was quiet, with muffled snores just audible from other tenants, appropriately asleep. The night seemed as any other

night would, save for the presence of these two masked women, thought the man. He allowed them to lead him down out of his building, where, by the front doors, he stopped.

“How did you get in, and where are you taking me?” His querulous voice quavered in the nighttime chill. “There is no time to explain. This is the sign you have been waiting for. We know you’re different. We know you’re special. We are here to protect you,” one of the women replied. “Follow us.”

They led him along the road, keeping up a brisk jog throughout the time, as the streets were as quiet as they’d ever been, and the lamps overhead, some of which now burned violet, watched down, wondering what all the fuss was about. Indeed, the man himself was wondering that, as they went further and further from his building, and the streetlights were growing sparser as well.

They arrived at an alleyway, down which there were no lights, and all that could be made out were the two tire tracks of gravel with dilapidated, likely abandoned, garages and loading bays on either side. Somewhere in the distance a raccoon lolloped off to a more quiet locale, with more recycling bins.

“Are you sure this is the right way?” the man asked. “Couldn’t you at least tell me your names?” The two women turned in their flight, looked at each other, and then looked at him. “There is no time to explain. This is the sign you have been waiting for,” they said in unison, before resuming their rapid movement down the alleyway.

The man followed a few paces, before turning around to look back the way he’d gone. The way was blocked by two bulky silhouettes in the dark. He turned around to inform the two women that they weren’t alone, but found them gone, having melded into the dark without his noticing their disappearance.

The figures behind him came closer. “No time to explain. This is the sign you’ve been waiting for. This is what difference gets you,” and what few lights could still just barely be seen in the distance, went out.

‘Revolue’ The man sat ahead of his companion, each nursing the dregs of his drink. The last few patrons had trickled out of the inn, and these two were all that remained, wiling away the hours passing tales back and forth. The previous tale now having ended, the elderly of the two cleared his throat and began anew:

‘It was many moons ago. The squirrels, of course, had been plotting for aeons previous to that time. The infusion of black squirrels among the traditional greys had, by humanity writ-large been seen as an invasive species to be culled, a heterodoxy to be excised. This view was not shared by the greys, who in time intermingled among the blacks genetically and culturally. This was a dynamic time, where pamphleteering became a common pastime among the squirrels, and small squirrel cafes sprang up. There was a hum in the air, the hum - of revolution.

‘Having eventually procured the military-grade equipment necessary to level the scales of combat against their perceived aggressors, in the largest recorded acorn transaction of all time, the squirrels, believing in a mandate from the masses, took up arms against their overlords. A dark cloud passed over history at this time, with the pall a sanguine shade of blood on all sides. Squirrel families were riven asunder and entire generations of squirrels obliterated, all while their efforts increasingly seemed in vain.

‘All the while the raccoons watched on, biding their time, picking up the dead and the detritus alike, making use of all that the conflict had seemingly stolen the use of. They used these parts to further edify their position, ultimately reinforcing the urban boundaries against panthers, and ensuring that raccoons stood in lockstep as the machine-gun beat of progress progressed.

‘One day, two raccoons were up late, having finished the last of their bag, and now with little else to do to pass the time, they set to chatting, and one said to the other:

“Hey imagine this story which starts with:

The man sat ahead of his companion, each nursing the dregs of his drink.

‘Ash’ There once was a young damsel named Ash, scarcely old enough to be entrusted with trips to the market, who lived with her father, a writer, and mother in a large and noble house. Ash had hair as white as her namesake, and pink eyes. Her mother, a frail and wispy creature who’d little strength at the best of times, was soon taken ill, and passed away in the spring of Ash’s twelfth year. Ash remembered her father weeping over her, as he patted her head on the ride home from the funeral.

The father, a man with a certain dark feline quality, lonely and unrequited, took a second wife, a thin, active, lady who was immensely attractive, but of limited emotional depth. She brought into the home a set of two twins, Ash’s younger stepsisters, who despite their youth were immensely headstrong, and would not suffer their wills to be contravened. Soon, Ash found herself on her hands and knees at regular intervals, rhythmically scrubbing the floors at her stepmother’s behest, as the twins looked on and giggled at her. They had black hair and black almond eyes, which they squeezed shut as they shook with giggles.

Ash tried to complain to her father of her treatment, but he was too busy writing more strange and confusing stories, or perhaps it was poetry, Ash couldn’t be sure. One day, he announced there was to be a release event for his latest work, and that most of the city’s elite would be invited. Ash wanted more than anything to be able to walk the red carpet with her father and see him as he launched his latest text, but her stepmother insisted that she stay home and clean the toilet.

While scrubbing the toilet diligently, as Ash did all her tasks, she scrubbed particularly vigorously — and out from the toilet’s drain sprung a genie godfather! “Hello Little Ash”, said the genie. “How would you like to attend your father’s

release?” Ash was able to lisp out a reply in the affirmative, and hardly had the “Weth” left her lips, but she found her shabby and threadbare garments transformed into the most slinky minidress in soft pink with teal highlights.

“But genie godfadder,” Ash lisped, “how wiw I get to the recepthon?” The genie told Ash to bring him a melon, and Ash did so, so that he could turn it into a magnificent coach! When asked about the drivers for the coach, Ash was instructed to provide a couple of shrews, which took some catching, but were ultimately turned into a pair of hulking but obedient guards-cum-drivers for the coach. A couple of ponies were purloined from a nearby field, and had ribbons tied in their hair, much as Ash had ribbons tied in hers.

The genie godfather urged her to leave with all due haste, but to take note not to stay past midnight, or else her accoutrements would become as they had been. Ash looked down at the airy pink muslin that spun around her with each movement, wondering whether her father might like the ensemble, and finally free her from her stepmother’s yoke.

Ash arrived with great pomp and splendour at the release, and saw her father at the head near the dais, and her twin stepsisters and stepmother close at hand. She went over to them, thinking they would be happy to see her. “And who might this charming creature be?” Asked her father, bending down to kiss her hand. Ash refused to speak, afraid that her speech impediment might give her away. She simply remained close to her father, and when her stepmother was away refreshing their drinks at one stage, her father took her hand, and squeezed it.

Ash was thunderstruck, and not necessarily in the most pleasant of manners, but as he guided her, without the other guests noticing, into a secluded hallway and began to make his intent known, she only welcomed the advance. All of a sudden, the clock began to toll, and Ash realized the time had come to take flight, and took to her heels. But as she ran, a ribbon fell from her hair, and her father caught it, holding it to his cheek as he surveyed the fleeing figure.

When Ash arrived back at home, she found her muslin dress had become the same rags she’d worn earlier. All that was left her was one of the pink ribbons from her hair, which she tucked away for safekeeping. Soon, the rest of her family arrived, but were none the wiser, and her father would not leave off speculating as to who the young lady who’d attended and been so quiet had been.

The next day there was a news bulletin released, Ash’s father would pay handsomely for information about who the young lady who’d attended his release the night previous had been. It wasn’t until Ash presented him, very sheepishly, with the ribbon, that he realized what a lucky father he was, but vowed never to write of it.

‘Will and the Sinkhole’ There once was a young man by the name of Will, who lived on a farm with his mother, tending their dried-up cow, and tilling the soil

at regular intervals. The soil was rarely very forthcoming, due to the presence of a battery recycling plant at close proximity to the homestead. Times were tough, and the cow was giving rather less milk and rather more passive aggression than his mother felt entirely decorous.

“I don’t see how we can keep Old Bess any longer, Will”, his mother told him one soft April morning as the verdant tint was just beginning to spread through the stunted and withered husks of once-proud Garry oaks, which were doing their best to shrug forth buds, albeit in the presence of huge quantities of lithium. “You must take her to the market, and sell her for the best price she’ll fetch. A butcher should be able to make some good of her”.

“Wouldn’t count on it”, Bess contributed, her tail swatting away the indomitable midges that sought to feed on her unmentionable bits, though she didn’t terribly mind the flies, or the notion of being eaten for that matter. All she really wanted was someone to read grotesque bedtime stories to her, but given as that was well beyond Will’s purview, Will being illiterate, was resigned to her fate. Someday someone might grace her with a story. Maybe the butcher would know a couple, hopefully twisted ones.

“Hush, Bess. I’m sure we’ll make plenty of good of you. Someone will want you for a pet, or some other such companion I’m sure. You are a blessed cow, Bess, and people will surely sense it”. So-saying, Will took up Bess’s leash and walked with her past the battery recycling plant, through an abandoned airfield, and ultimately made it to the local organic farmer’s market hosted in the shade of a cluster of weatherbeaten billboards advertising eyelash extensions at a nearby salon.

Setting immediately to work, Will wandered around the various stalls, half of which were selling soap that smelled funny and candles that smelled funnier, doing his best to advertise Bess, letting the vendors inspect her at as much length as they liked, which was seldom very long due to Bess’s habit of muttering incomprehensible comments about plot development and characterization from unreliable narrators who refused to let sentences die when they should. Will tended to go slack-jawed during these inspections and digressions, and his eyes would glaze, before one eye wandered left and the other down, and ultimately he woke himself from his introspection when the glob of saliva from his mouth fell and hit the hand holding the leash.

None of the vendors was very interested in Bess, a situation apparently unaided by Will’s constant admonitions that the vendors must treat Bess right, and milk her thrice daily regardless of milk’s emergence, per Bess’s request. One vendor, a small charcoal grey squirrel selling munitions, was particularly down on the topic, and wouldn’t so much as admire Bess’s fine mottled skin.

“What good is a bovine leper to me, kid? Look, all I want is to completely waste the one percent and feast on the proverbial flesh of billionaires as my squirrel comrades topple capitalism’s Bastille. Sell me a Reign of Terror, not some washed up cow that can’t even knock down a reinforced bunker’s main gate”.

With which comment, the squirrel resumed polishing a .45 caliber submachine gun which had quite the shine already. Will, disheartened, wound his way homewards.

They made it back to the airfield, and were passing over the grass, which poked up hopefully from the thick brown of the quagmire. “You could always try to milk me on the way, if you’re feeling thirsty”, said Bess, hopefully, and fully aware that she had not provided a drop of milk this millennium. Will, ever faithful to those around him, dutifully set about squeezing the udders, as Bess did her best to keep from vocalizing. The crows, lopsidedly wandering with patrolmen’s easy steps, decided there were other abandoned airfields near battery recycling plants to patrol, and went there instead.

There, Will encountered a strange looking man, whose black leather vest had several white and red sets of lettering patched on, and who sat astride a powerful looking motorbike, his head bald as could be, sunglasses occluding Will’s view of his eyes. The man was revving his motorbike around the airfield, sending great wakes of mud flying as he careened around the space. Upon seeing Will at his work, the man bore down upon him, stopping his motorbike just in time, as Will wondered what the squirrel had wanted bad weather for anyway. It was plenty wet here.

The biker put one foot down off the bike, there was a sucking squelch that sounded like the mud was rather pleased with his boot, and would be doing its best to keep it present. “Hey bro, nice cow”. The biker nodded approvingly at Bess, and revved his engine loudly. Bess whimpered. “How’d you like to sell me her? I’ll trade you a bottle of magic potion for her. It’ll send you to another dimension”.

Having never seen another dimension, and being by this point well and truly tired of gently teasing Bess’s udders, Will gladly accepted the vial of ominously purple liquid from the biker. Will had never seen a vial inside a canister before. This stuff had to be powerful. When the biker left, Will tried to open the canister, but was prevented from doing so by the need to apparently apply some kind of pressure while spinning the cap, which was almost like being able to pat one’s head as one rubbed one’s belly, which is to say, impossible. Feeling cheated, but hopeful that his mother could advise him as to how to extract the elixir he sought from within the canistered vial, Will went home.

The chemical taint was heavy on the wind that night, as whenever the air currents had their domicile downwind, Will and his mother felt they could taste the tang of charged metal. Will approached the door of their home, from which the sounds of heavy trap music could be heard emanating, as his mother was washing dishes, and paused in his tracks. There could be no question that the biker would take care of Bess; Will could tell by the way the biker had taken over the milking so delicately, and oddly sweatily given the chill. He entered, holding the vial out before him like a buckler.

He exited very shortly thereafter once more, airborne and travelling backwards

at speed, and landed with the flat sound of bones not quite breaking but certainly complaining at their utmost. After him, his mother came, her face the same crimson as the biker's lettering had been, looking considerably more dangerous.

"You traded our last earthly asset for a vial of I beg your pardon come again what now?" Will quivered in fright and confusion. Perhaps mother had already seen the other dimension. She snatched the encased vial from Will, and with a deft movement that struck fear into his soul, she was able to open the canister without so much as saying the lord's prayer backwards or stretching. She took out the vial, filled with the mysterious purple fluid, and poured the fluid onto the ground. "We'll see how many dimensions you need to run through to get away from me, my boy". And his mother walked back inside, closed the door, and summarily locked it. An owl in the distance hooted approvingly. After having surmised that she must have locked the door on purpose to keep him out, Will lay down, and fell asleep.

He awoke to find a sinkhole in front of him. That hadn't been there when he'd gone to sleep. It was roughly the size of a manhole cover, and Will couldn't see how deep it went. He went back to the front door, and knocked, hoping that now it was morning his mother might take some pity on him, and let him change out of the clothes that were sodden through, and perhaps have some cream with his morning coffee. The door was flung open, however, with such vitriolic force, that Will's hopes for resolution were immediately dashed, just as Will himself was dashed by the swing of the door, lost his footing, and fell backwards, down into the sinkhole.

Down, down, down, Will tumbled headfirst until he landed with a dull thud on a wooden surface. Having landed on his face, and with his brain taking most of the force of the fall, Will had damaged nothing important, and shook himself off with bemusement. Somewhere in the distance he could hear a booming voice yelling, "No you don't understand, I can't just size up the waist that large because then the pants won't be long enough. I need a 451 in the waist and a 420 in the length. I can't have 451 in the waist and 33 in the length. Those would be shorts, you imbecile! I need these for the Giant Disco-Dance Off in three days time and you're the only ones who can ship here by then." It was somewhat difficult to hear this, however, due to the insistent throbbing baselines emanating from one side of the cavernous room.

Will looked up, and saw that he was on a massive dining room table, complete with a half-eaten dinner thereupon it, which was as big as Will himself was. Will looked at what was on the plate, and wished that he hadn't. In the distance, he saw a huge, lumbering silhouette, holding a telephone to its ear, dimly backlit by the screen of a computer which was open to a page showing various sets of denim trousers. Will scanned the room, and made out a drum-machine on the wall to the left of the giant, which didn't appear to be plugged in, but which had various lit up buttons, the lights of which were undulating chromatically.

There was a soft, squeaky “Quack to the quack to quack to quack quack-quack”, behind Will, and he turned to see a small yellow duck eying him pensively. Beneath the duck was a small pile of golden eggs, about the size of a fingernail each, and as Will met the duck’s eye, another one pinged out from beneath the duck, landing upon the steadily-increasing pile. Behind the duck, on the wall, was the title deed for the battery recycling plant. Will saw this, and immediately knew what it represented. If he could get the title deed back to his mother, then they could take over ownership of the battery recycling plant together, and with her powerful door-swinging skills and his quick wit, they were sure to figure out how to recharge some of the batteries. He ran over the table, grabbed the deed off the wall, and tore it into little bits so he wouldn’t need to get it creased in his pockets.

“...So how about if we were to do shorts then; what’s the longest...” The giant was still doing his best to acquire proper pants, but appeared to be being hampered by the normative sizing framework which pervades fashion everywhere and is indicative of the unacknowledged stigma facing vertically abnormal cryptids. Suddenly, the giant froze. “Fee-fie-fo-fum, fee-fie-fo-fum, fee-fie-fo-fum, I smell the blood... of a simpleton!” He turned around from where he had been standing. Right as he was about to fully rotate around and make eye contact with Will, the duck, having stopped quacking rhythmically at the sound of the first “Fee”, hit Will with the force of a freight-train and bowled him to the stone floor. Will landed on his head again, which being so soft, was a fairly silent landing.

Will now recognized the danger he was in. If he wasn’t careful, the giant might not be able to acquire the properly tailored couture, and might have to resort to taking Will’s clothes and stitching them into some lurid Frankenstein trousers. Then there was the matter of the giant’s dinner... It had made Will think of food and now he was reminded that he’d not eaten since the previous day. The thought of barbecued duck rose, unprompted, in his consciousness, and he dwelt on it momentarily as one eye made a break for the ceiling as the other nodded gently. He woke himself again when the saliva hit his hand, and the duck gestured towards the hole in the ceiling.

To get to the hole in the ceiling, Will would have to navigate a way of climbing up. The duck, despite its hefty payload which was still pinged out of it at regular intervals, was apparently capable of flight, but Will doubted it could carry him, as it was so small, scarcely larger than a bath toy, even. So Will had to think quickly. He could hear the giant wandering his way, and keeping up that horrible refrain of “Fee-fie-fo-fum, I smell the blood of a simpleton!” The giant would be upon him in moments unless he thought of something quickly.

All of a sudden it came to him, and he grabbed the duck and ran around the table towards the drum-machine, which had maintained the wobbling low notes of a grungy after-hours joint throughout the proceedings. Will arrived at the drum-machine, and saw if he could find any disco options. There, indeed, was the disco button, complete with mirror-ball icon. With a feeling of relief mixed with trepidation, for this was but part of the plan, he hit the button, and was

immediately gratified by the effect. The giant paused in his “Fum”, and his foot began tapping.

Now was the risky part. Will snuck around the table to where the giant’s foot was tapping, the giant himself looking off into the distance, with a wistful but determined expression on his face. As the track’s synth set in, Will saw the finger wobble, and knew time was off the essence. He made motions directing that the duck should fly towards the hole in the roof where Will had entered, and, hoping the message was understood and reciprocated, quickly tiptoed to the giant’s feet. Here, he saw why the giant had been so intent upon his purchase. The trousers the giant wore were tattered and torn, threadbare and hardly sufficient to be said to cover what they had to. This pleased Will, as it afforded him all the handholds and footholds he needed to ascend to the giant’s waist. He had a fifty percent chance of selecting the correct one.

Determining that the giant was likely to be right-handed, Will made his way to the left hip, but was careful to avoid the left hand, which was now planted there, as the giant planted his legs at shoulder-width, and took his right forefinger, placed it on his left hip, and made to raise the finger in the air. The giant did this once to the beat. The giant did it a second time. On the third beat, Will leapt onto the finger as it was sweeping upwards, and before the giant could react, leapt off at the height of the ascent, and grabbed hold of the tunnel’s rim, pulling himself inside.

Beneath him, the giant’s howl of rage mingled with the “Ah-ah-ah-ah” of the track in the background. The giant fell to his knees, and cursed the enchanted drum-machine, as well as the giant’s own love of disco. Will crawled up the hole, back towards the surface, with the duck just ahead of him, intermittently shooting down tiny golden eggs on to him. Will didn’t mind one bit.

‘Grasping’ There once was a man who was a staunch realist. Wedded to logic, reason, and the testimony of his senses, he strode through the world and was the envy of those around him who were less adept at determining fact from fiction. One day, he decided to stride over to the old nuclear power plant, where he had heard there were fewer people around to bother him with their intangible words. The man didn’t believe in words, as nobody had ever shown him one he could grasp.

“Hey, you, stop right there! This area is highly radioactive and not to be entered without explicit permission from the Head Tyrant himself!” A lady in military uniform was approaching the man, who could see the large sweeping sides of the reactor not twenty-two meters ahead of him. He paused, momentarily, then remembered that words could not be grasped, and not seeing anything wrong with the area, continued walking forwards, ignoring the warning with perfect composure. He had heard of radiation before, and knew what the warning meant, but he did not see a danger, nor could he grasp one, and so he dismissed the nonsense as just that, and wandered towards the reactor, behind which was a large pool of water.

“I warn you, I’ll need to use force if you do not turn around and go back from where you came”, the lady had a hand on her hip, where her handgun was holstered. The man, aware that he’d been spoken to, but entirely alien to the notion of speech as being impactful, continued walking forwards, passing the reactor, and approaching the pool. He wanted to get to the other side of the pool, and was heartened to find when he sank his hand in the water that it could not be grasped. Satisfied that the water thus was inconsequential, and likely not to be believed in, he waded in, and began to make towards the other side.

Then, the man happened upon something he had to grasp, as the bullet was kept nestled in his torso, and he kept hold of that until he could hold nothing any more.

‘Three(ish) Silly Soats Bluff’ Once upon a time, on the verdant marine slopes at the base of the underwater volcanic mountain ranges, there lived a group of three soats. These horned and bihoofed marine mammals ate the kelp which grew on the slopes, and captured the oxygen gas released by the kelp, with the help of their mermaid herdsman. The soats and mermaid breathed only very rarely, having become habituated to holding their breath, as is the way with soats and mermaids.

The soats had been grazing upon one particular slope for quite some time, and had all but depleted the kelp to an untenable level. The kelp was a boon due to its double service, and was accordingly the most tended of the mer crops. However, the risk of kelp was that due to its being consumed as foodstuff, a group could inadvertently cut off its oxygen supply if it were greedy, which was an adjective that the mermaid suggested these particular soats had been flirting with, though they themselves were loth to admit it.

There was, the soats could see, a field of fresh kelp on the other side of a deep gully, and they yearned to feast on the overgrown patches of kelp, and harvest the bubbles of oxygen they could see teeming on the surface of each plant, like morning dew. The chasm which lay between the soats current and suboptimal kelp patch was profoundly deep, and the sides of it were composed of jagged, slippery rocks with the occasional urchin poking out from among the spears of stone.

The soats could not swim upwards, due to their cumbersome weight, but had long tails and forelegs, with which they could effect a form of hybridized run-swimming. They could leap great distances with a running start and consistent pumps of their tails once off the seafloor. The mermaid, naturally, could swim indefinitely without needing to light upon solid seafloor at any stage, but he was keen to keep his herd together. Having recognized that his herd might struggle to cross the chasm on their own, he swam off to ascertain if there were spare mermaids close by who could help him to shepherd the flock across (soats jump further with mermaids holding them aloft).

The first, and least intelligent of the soats approached the ledge separating them

from the promised kelp field, and was met with an indignant cloud of bubbles. Up rose a stout troll in scuba gear and a soft pink wetsuit, who made it clear with a truly spectacular degree of gesticulation and bodily diagramming, all the while making use of a plastic straw to make his meaning understood, that this was a toll chasm, and that it would cost several pieces of lanthanum and cerium to cross the chasm.

The soat, finding this oddly specific, intimated as much with a flick of his tail, and informed the troll via primitive telepathic transfer (soats are the first known marine lifeform beginning to work this out, but which is complicated by how many of their thoughts are about kelp), that the next soat to approach the chasm was considerably more affluent than the first soat, and would doubtless have more lanthanum and cerium to contribute for the toll, if he would only let the first soat pass unmolested on to the promised kelp fields beyond.

The troll blew bubbles pensively, and ultimately gesticulated that this would be acceptable, allowing the first soat to successfully attempt the leap on his own and begin feasting on the kelp first. Between voluminous gulps of masticated kelp, the first soat turned to see his companions on the opposite side of the chasm, and pitied their slow-wittedness.

The next soat, who was of average intellect, saw the first soat jump, and made to discover the result. On seeing, at closer proximity, that the first soat had arrived safely, the second soat approached the ledge of the chasm to inspect the jump and plan his run up. His view was suddenly occluded by an expectant cloud of bubbles. Up rose the troll who was able to express to this soat the status of the chasm as a tolled traffic artery between slopes, and the necessity of the soat now contributing sufficient rare-earth elements to cover not only his crossing, but that of his preceder, who had assured the troll of deferred payment.

The soat, highly flummoxed, had no choice but to extend the ploy, and once again a soat was allowed to pass, on the telepathically communicated understanding that the next soat to arrive would be a lanthanum magnate with extensive cerium reserves to cover all three of their crossings. The second soat arrived on the opposite side of the chasm, and began to feed on the kelp, taking gentle mouthfuls and swishing them about to aid his digestion, all while he wondered whether the third soat could outwit the troll.

The third and most intelligent soat, having seen the second one jump, and now being assured by both's crossing that nothing could be amiss, approached the chasm, but was met with an impatient cloud of bubbles. Up rose the troll, rubbing his hands gleefully, and immediately informing the soat that he could not take credit at this late stage, and that three soats passage must be paid for in lanthanum and cerium. The soat, telepathically, communicated that this was patently ridiculous, and that far from being a rare earth element tycoon, he was, in fact, a mere soat. The other two soats had lied.

Upon hearing this, the troll flew into a rage, and with some truly gruesome motions demonstrated the prospective untimely fate of each of those two soats,

if they ever dared to cross his chasm once more. The third goat, content that without the other two he would be able to feast on the remaining kelp on the current slopes without fear of it becoming depleted at the hand of three mouths, realized he now had no need of crossing.

The other two goats, having two mouths to feed as opposed to the third's one, eventually depleted the kelp on that side of the chasm, and had to find the cerium and lanthanum they owed the troll in order to be reunited with the third goat. The herd waited for their mermaid herdsman's return, but this never materialized as he was murdered in a brutal interspecies conflict.

'Platilocks and the Three Bikers' There once was a young lady, with hair of the purest pale plat, and pink eyes. She lived with her father, a writer, and her stepmother, a veritable slave-driver, as well as her twin step-siblings, who she was always trying to out-cute. She was happy with her position, although sometimes her father was more difficult to satisfy than she might like, and she'd grown tired of facilitating all her step-mother's cleaning quota, which included some truly demeaning rituals of sanitation, not limited to toilet scrubbing. The young lady was named Ash Platilocks, after her hair, and she took great pride in this feature of hers, which she would often augment through the application of soft pink bows.

One day, Platilocks decided to venture out from her home into the forest yonder. She'd scrubbed the bathroom to within an inch of its life, had acceded to all her father's odd requests, although she still wasn't sure why he'd felt the need to keep her on a leash while she'd done the scrubbing, and the manner in which he'd watched her while so-doing had been disconcertingly appreciable. When he'd purred, it had reminded Platilocks distinctly of a panther. Confused, and not willing to discuss it with the twins, who were busy sleeping in, in the bed they shared, that morning, Platilocks went out into the forest, and wandered wherever her heart took her, following butterfly flight paths and seeking out raccoon dens (none of which she found, the dens being hidden beyond her ability to locate them).

Soon, however, Platilocks was lost. It was only when she happened upon a cottage made entirely of sweet edibles that she recognized the risk to her. If she ate any of that house she would swell up, and then her father would never look at her the same way, and would spend longer tucking in the twins than he did her. The thought did not bear thinking about. She began to panic, and ran helter-skelter through the trees until she had entirely lost her way. She sat on a stump and washed her eyes in frustration, but on raising her head from her hands, noticed that she could hear the sounds of a river close at hand. She wandered to where the river bank was, and there, on the other side of the river, was a small house, two stories, with a large garage attached. She approached it warily.

In order to approach the house, Platilocks had to cross the river, there being no bridge spanning the water which gently stroked at her as she waded across. Her

teal and white striped tube-top and matching short-shorts clung even closer to her as she emerged from the coolly stimulating water, and she stood for a moment in the warm sunlight which shone on her, dripping contentedly and pondering what she ought to do next. The crows which watched from the crown of a nearby cedar were diligently taking notes in a splendid flowing cursive, but evidently too removed from the situation to try to aid her directly. Platilocks, still damp, decided she must press onwards.

By now being hopelessly lost, and very much desirous of finding her way back home again, Platilocks went up to the door and knocked thereupon, but no response emanated from the domicile. So, with reckless lack of forethought, the hapless child tried the door, and found, much to her surprise, that it swung open invitingly. She stepped inside, and found upon a table at one end several piles of ominous looking powders, from which strong chemical odours were emanating. A pocket scale was visible next door to these, as well as a truly staggering number of ridiculously tiny plastic zip-locks. At the other end of the table, were three plates, with a cheese sandwich on each. Taking a tiny whiff of each of the three powders, to aid her blessed noggin, Platilocks descended upon the cheese sandwiches, having been tempted by the confectionary cottage, she was sure these would be better for her figure, and was truly peckish.

The first sandwich was too sloppy, with the top piece of bread effectively coming off the slice of cheese, which was poorly positioned on the lower slice of bread. Platilocks tried to take a bite of it, but was prevented by the poor organization of the sandwich. She tried the second sandwich, but it had been so neatly assembled that to Platilocks it was a great sin to violate the integrity of such a perfectly prepared meal. She took a small bite of it, but felt it would be sacrilegious to eat any further. The third sandwich, ever so slightly askew, but largely correctly prepared, while not being just yet a work of art, was what Platilocks decided to fit all of into her. She whimpered as the last bit of sandwich disappeared down her oral cavity, and felt that she would really appreciate being able to read a little something now, to remind her of her father.

She went out of the kitchen, and into the living room adjacent. There, she found several comfy chairs, each with reading matter placed beside it. She went to the first chair, and picked up the tabloid magazine which lay next to it, but the tabloid was too trashy, and so Platilocks returned it to its approximate position, and went on to the next chair. Here, there was a book as big as a brick, written in what certainly appeared to be English, but which contained so many multisyllabic words in such odd configurations, that Platilocks wasn't sure where to begin, so she put the work down. Finally, upon finding that the third text was a story about a princess who met a prince at a ball, and being assured that there was no implication that the young woman needed a father figure, Platilocks sat to read it in full.

Soon, however, she found that she was growing sleepy, and so she got up from the comfy chair, and went in search of a bedroom. Platilocks found the staircase, a spiralling affair that swept up from the ground floor to the upper one above,

and ascended the steps. She found one large bedroom above, with three beds along one side of the room. The first bed was messy, without having been made that morning by the individual who'd left it. She lay down on it, but could not be comfy on such a messy bed. The second bed was far too neat, with the duvet fastidiously tucked into the gap between mattress and frame. She lay down on it, but dared not disturb it, and so got up again. The third bed, with a corner of the duvet turned back from the mattress, was just inviting enough, and it was here that Platilocks lay down to rest.

Platilocks dreamt of squirrel revolutionaries laying siege to the final fortification of the elite and occult societal sector. In her mind's eye she saw the squirrels toppling the turret-towers one by one, while whizzing bolts of power smote squirrel turtle-formations, at which point the last few of the elite occultists finally surrendered. The watching raccoons were diligently clearing away the battlefield's waste, and Platilocks herself was engaged in constructing the new constitutional documents of the liberated land, which documents she had used to begin her own writing career. This was a very successful career, or would have been, if the dream had not been so rudely interrupted.

She was awoken by the sound of several engines, insufficiently muffled, approaching. Platilocks issued a muffled squeak of dismay. Looking out of the window, she saw three leather-clad bikers, two men and a woman, astride their steel steeds, which would be far more noble if they weren't so obnoxiously loud, approaching the house. Suddenly aware of the situation, Platilocks dove under the covers to try to hide herself from the residents of the home, who had, predictably, returned. She heard the sound of the garage door retracting, and the slow sputtering of the motorbikes pulling into their respective spots in the garage. The door between the garage and the kitchen opened, then slammed shut. Platilocks could hear the bikers below, who were understandably bemused. The piles of powder of these merchants were significant enough, and Platilocks's constitution sensitive enough, that she'd not taken enough to be noticed by such, but there were other signs.

"Someone's been nibbling on my cheese sandwich", said the first male biker. "Someone's been nibbling on my cheese sandwich too", said the female biker. "Someone's been and eaten all of my cheese sandwich, look there's none left!" Said the second male biker. Platilocks' stomach, still filled with cheese sandwich, stirred guiltily. She heard the clomping of heavy footwear as the bikers went into the living room. "Someone's been reading my tabloid magazine", said the first male biker. "Someone's been reading my collected works", said the female biker. "Someone's been reading my original fairytale complete with uncomfortable but largely hidden subtext", said the second male biker, "and look, they've finished it without recognizing just how dark the implications are".

The clomping came up the stairs, step by step the three bikers approached where Platilocks was hidden underneath the duvet in the third bed. "Someone's been lying on my bed", the first male biker said. "Someone's been lying on my bed", the female biker said. "Someone's lying in my bed right now", said the second

male biker, “what shall we do with her?” Platilocks looked up from where she had been discovered, sucking her thumb at the end of the bed, hoping not to be discovered under the duvet. She told them, hesitatingly, that they might do with her as they pleased, which was only reasonable given the condition she was found in. The bikers made to approach her, and include her in their book circle’s reading for the day, upon which realization of their intent and what thematic focal points corollary discussions might reveal, Platilocks defenestrated herself, and stole one of the motorbikes to make good her escape on.

She thought, as she throttled the engine on what she hoped was the way home, that her father would not believe what had happened to her, and that now, at last, perhaps he would finally agree to include her in one of the stories he wrote. Elsewhere entirely, the crow delivered its notes to an underground raccoon den only accessible via cavern entrance, and the raccoons began integrating the field report in their recycling plans. Good could come of this, and the cursive was pretty.

‘Lil Mermaid’ The brutal marine interspecies conflict between elite occultist humans and mermaids having heated up, King Mermaid bid his daughter, Lil Mermaid, that she was only to visit the surface when she came of age, and even then only under cover of night. Having waited all throughout her life to finally see the hated humans who poisoned the waters in which she swam, Lil Mermaid was keen to finally be able to visit the land of perversity, when she reached her twenty-second birthday. She took her pet goat, Bubblez, with her, and swam towards the estuary where she knew she could be close to a major settlement, but relatively subtle about her presence. Besides, while you couldn’t see much of the major settlement itself, there were some old military fortifications covered in the humans’ paintings, Lil Mermaid had been told.

Following the instructions of King Mermaid, Lil Mermaid and Bubblez began their journey to the mouth of the river, wishing the sturgeon they passed on the way a good evening each. Upon arrival at the beach proper, a pebbled affair Lil Mermaid found, with sweeping forested cliffs crashing down into it, bit by geological bit, and indeed there were a pair of minor buildings, nothing compared with the marine palace back home, but nice enough in their quaint manner she supposed, swimming by the first one and peeking her head out of the water. Bubblez surfaced and snorted a puff of brackish water in her direction, because he’d noticed the distant wobble of a throbbing bassline mixed with the pound of an 808.

There, along the pebbled shoreline, stood a group of the humans, bumping and boogieing and getting down with all due alacrity at the water’s edge. Now, there is limited technology underwater, and as a result there is limited musical capacity. The most sophisticated mermaid ensembles are mixed species ensembles, with dolphins and whales making up aspects of certain groups repertoires, and even the occasional seal or sea lion included, but even such esteemed and advanced mermaid (and co.) musical tours de force pale in comparison to small human offerings, due to the sheer power offered by portable generators along-

side sound systems. Mermaids (and co.) also didn't have laser light shows, and Lil Mermaid was impressed. Bubblez, for his part, was already flicking the tips of his fluke to the beat.

All of a sudden, Lil Mermaid's heart leapt up into her mouth and insisted upon staying there, as she saw a man performing the most sublime motion, positioning both hands ahead of his waist, and then driving them back in sync while thrusting his waist forward, the hands forward as his waist went back, and so on. Lil Mermaid was stunned. Bubblez, for his part, was unimpressed, but unwilling to harsh what was so clearly her mellow at that moment. Suddenly, Lil Mermaid's thoughts were far from the harm that the humans had done, the suffering they wantonly inflicted wherever they trod, but were instead upon those motions. Such motions, they were, thought she, as became a prince, if only she might convert him to Mermaidism. Bubblez, for his part, intimated that he felt this unlikely (kelp) but would support her in anything (kelp over there) kelp.

So Lil Mermaid went to her confidante and homie C-Witch, who was renowned throughout the ocean for being one bad mother, including by her own children. C-Witch, a practitioner of marine magic who regularly contributed to soat telepathy research, knew almost all there was to know about cross-species transmutation spells, but regretted to inform Lil Mermaid "Mermaidism can't be converted into, and has to be inherited; however, I can transmute you into a human if that's really what you totally absolutely want, and I can only do that because it's a cosmic step-down, which means it's easier. Do you really want that though, Lil M?" Lil Mermaid pondered hard. Bubblez chewed kelp. She wanted to be with the dancer, that was for sure. His moves had been so... She shuddered with desire.

But she knew she had to be sure she wanted him, she knew she had to be sure it was to be a human life for her. So she waited and watched, frequenting the same beach often. It didn't take long. One evening, just as the sun had finally shed its last rays and dipped its last sliver below the horizon, there came the faint untuning of an insistent beat, mixed with a distorted saxophone and vocals chopped beyond recognition. Approaching at a fair clip was a party-boat, aboard which stood the same figure, her beloved, and he looked more resplendent than ever before. This time, she saw he had updated his repertoire considerably. Now, on this evening, it seemed he had a predilection towards putting his right leg into a space, then out of it, then back into it, before shaking the leg repeatedly. A slow pirouette would follow. He would then repeat this with his other leg, before the selfsame slow pirouette repeated. The inspired performance shook Lil Mermaid; she would never again doubt her beloved.

But all was not well on board. The captain appeared to have been engaging in the festivities, as the boat had drifted off course and into the rocky shoreline, which ruptured the hull, set the fuel tank alight, and ultimately led to a rippling explosion which sent newly minted cadavers flying every which way. Lil Mermaid, having had sufficient space twist her and the epicentre, swam to find

her beloved barely moving in the water. He had been at some remove from the blast, compared with many others onboard, but still would not have survived had it not been for Lil Mermaid's swimming him to shore, and depositing him on a sandy stretch a little ways from the pebbles, where she thought he would be more comfortable. Lil Mermaid waited until the morning light was dawning, and a hippie lady came down to the shoreline, found Lil Mermaid's beloved, and called paramedics.

Lil Mermaid went over to C-Witch's crib, and informed C-Witch that she was sure she wanted to be transformed into a human, no matter what it took. C-Witch rubbed her hands gleefully. She informed Lil Mermaid that she would cast the spell for Lil Mermaid, but Lil Mermaid would have to make a trade with her for the transmutation, as was ritual custom. Lil Mermaid solemnly nodded, and asked what would be needed. C-Witch practically purred out that, in order to make Lil Mermaid into Lil Woman, Lil Mermaid would need to transfer to C-Witch her ability to spit fire bars, and drop mad lyrical heat. C-Witch wanted to be able to majorly freestyle, and was irked with the regularity at which Lil Mermaid's lines could be heard being repeated by younger mermaids, while C-Witch's lines remained unrecited at any given time.

This was the point at which Bubblez, who since he'd been a kid had seen the incredible talent that Lil Mermaid had when she rapidly orated in rhythmic verse improvisationally, interjected. He implored Lil Mermaid to not make such a deal with C-Witch. C-Witch's proposal would see Lil Mermaid without her outlet, and Bubblez was sobered by the thought of this. C-Witch added that in order to remain a human, Lil Mermaid would need to dance with her beloved before anyone else did, and that failure to do so would mean her ultimate return to beneath the waves, with her bars permanently transferred to C-Witch, no take backs. Bubblez wouldn't have allowed it, but was momentarily distracted in a kelp patch, and hardly noticed the change until it was almost complete. Lil Mermaid had become Lil Woman, and was kicking towards shore.

There, much to her great dismay, she found a sight that would haunt her for the remainder of her days, as there was a hippie drum circle in full swing on the beach, and who should be dancing there, but her beloved, with the hippie woman who had found him when she'd dropped him on the beach that morning, her hips gyrating upon his as the circle played a reverberating cacophony across and out of over the waves. Lil Woman was appalled at his engaging in such poor dancing technique, and immediately cast off all thought of him as her beloved, but the damage was done. He had been her beloved when she swore to C-Witch, and now she would need to return beneath the waves, permanently bereft of her potent rhyme schemes. At least she'd get to see Bubblez again.

All of a sudden, C-Witch appeared, and said that she would give Lil Woman one final chance, to regain her bars, if only she could defeat C-Witch in a dance-off to the soundtrack of the hippie drum circle, as this was a caveat provided in ritual transmutative magic. If she should lose, her tail would also be taken from her, and she would be left to drift on the current, like sea foam. Lil Woman, seeing

little recourse, decided that she would accept the challenge, and began to limber up. The previously beloved and his hippie girlfriend were enlisted as judges, each practicing the utmost equanimity, with the wider hippie circle focusing on establishing the sickest beat pattern known to man or marine mammal, ensuring the contestants ample material to get down with.

The two began to truly get groovy, but ultimately it appeared as if C-Witch would be the victor in the contest, as she was certainly the more confident and practiced in her bopping, and she kept weaving with a dexterity that the novice Lil Woman couldn't hope to match. The hippies drummed louder, faster, with stranger and more inconsistent yet reminiscent textures appearing unbidden in the music. Trancelike, the dancers spun. It was only when, all of a sudden, Bubblez flopped out onto the beach and began dancing with her, Lil Woman was able to boogie all the better for her friends' presence, even at one stage being launched by Bubblez, not particularly high, but nonetheless it was a launching, and C-Witch knew she was beaten.

'Platilocks and the Seven Hippies' In a certain timeline, Platilocks returned home on her motorbike. In a certain timeline she resumed her chores with no complaint, and with an appreciation for her station which would baffle anyone poorly versed in the arts of internal ironic processing. Her Evil Stepmother, secretly involved with the elite occultists, had obtained via witchcraft a magic mirror, to which she was engaged in asking the kind of deeply significant questions which warrant magical intervention.

"Mirror mirror on the wall, who is the hottest of them all?" The Evil Stepmother asked the magic mirror, which rued its own construction, but had to play the cards it had been dealt. "Evil Stepmother the only hot you are is bothered. Platilocks is the show stopper". Upon hearing this, the Evil Stepmother blew her lid, becoming utterly apoplectic and insensible to reason. She found Platilocks's father, the writer, and informed him that he needed to get rid of Platilocks, as she was eating more than was her due, and the last book release was receiving poor returns, necessitating their shrinking the budget.

"Take Platilocks deep in the forest, and there do with her what you will, ensuring she does not live. You must return to me with her heart as a token, which is a reasonable request I am making". The father agreed to take Platilocks deep in the forest, and there do away with her. In order to minimize any struggle or mess, the father acquired a .22 handgun and ammunition, as well as a small switchblade, from a squirrel who'd given up on revolutionary fervour, and sold out to the market forces in a moment of treason against his species.

The father informed Platilocks that they needed to go on a walk into the woods together, so that they could bond better and get some one on one father daughter time, which excited Platilocks very much at the thought of. She had some plot lines that she was thinking of playing with, and wanted her father's feedback. They walked down the path that led towards the mountains, all the way until the path ended, and they had to bushwhack on, as all the while Platilocks

regaled her father with her ideas for conflicting characterization of archetypes traditionally seen as sympathetic. She didn't fear the panthers, though she knew they were out there somewhere, because her father would protect her if it came down to it.

When they came to a nurse tree, out of which was growing a slender sapling, the father suddenly informed her that sometimes conflicting characters were just bad people, and that any attempts to humanize them were attempts by individuals to shirk responsibility for very real wrongs. He drew the handgun, and told Platilocks to kneel, and close her pink eyes. Platilocks was stunned, and immensely hesitant, but didn't cry, something she would only do when she was told to, instead she knelt, and said, "Father, I agree that bad characters need to be punished and clearly understood as such, but I also don't think anyone is past redemption, and I think stories should provide opportunities for growth, and if you let me live, permit me my escape, then I will never return and distract you".

The father, recognizing what narrative plat he'd just been handed, if he could only wrap it in enough displaced distance to render it psychologically telling but not downright damning, decided to allow Platilocks to flee. He helped her to her feet chivalrously, and bid her make her way towards the mountains, where neither the Evil Stepmother nor he himself would be likely to find her. "Good luck Platilocks. Thanks for all the stories and plot mechanic discussions. Someday, I hope to read some of your work, whether it's romantic or otherwise". And with that he left her, shivering, but not with cold, never to see each other again. The raccoons would ensure this.

Speaking of raccoons, it was on his way back whence he'd came, towards the family home, that the father noticed a very large, but apparently dehydrated raccoon, who was panting and moving sluggishly ahead of the father. He wasted no time in shooting it through the head, and used the switchblade to extract its heart for the Evil Stepmother. When she was presented with it, she was careful to season it carefully, before eating it with relish. The raccoons, while somber on the occasion due to one of their own's sacrifice, were unwilling to grieve overly much, as they understood that darkness had to be met head on for the greater good of the narrative. Platilocks was alive. Raccoon Em would be missed.

All the while, Platilocks was venturing through the forest, wondering why on earth she wasn't in a timeline where anybody gave a single hoot about her. She crossed seven mountains, travelling through the day and the next night, followed attentively by crow eyes wherever she went, her movements tracked on a raccoon map at their headquarters. Her thighs were killing her by the end of the seventh mountain, but eventually, the morning after her departure from home the previous day, she came across a lush gully beyond the seventh mountain, where was hidden a small campsite, complete with seven small tents, each with a hammock next door, all arranged around a large fire pit, with a large communal dining tent off to one side.

At the table in the dining tent, Platilocks found seven servings of granola with oat milk, seven cups of kombucha, and seven water-pipes, she ate a spoonful of each bowl of granola, and drank a sip of each cup of kombucha, had the tiniest puff on each water-pipe, but was ultimately exhausted from her journey, and went to sleep in a string hammock on the periphery of the campsite. Soon, the hippies came back from the organic cherry orchards that they tended, and found that someone had been eating of their granola, drinking of their kombucha, smoking of their water-pipes, and snoozing in their hammock. The hippies didn't dare to wake Platilocks, who they found had a really cool style. They dug the teal stripes and her liberated but bright outfit.

That night one hippie was kept awake at any given time, watching over Platilocks, with each taking an hour's turn to act as sentinel over her. Upon her waking up the next morning, the hippies questioned Platilocks, who recounted the tale of her upbringing, and the culmination in her expulsion from her home, alongside her father's final kindness to her. The hippies politely, and gently, informed Platilocks that what she'd experienced was bald faced abuse and the kind of suffering that they wouldn't wish on the most extractive bureaucrat; they admired her strength in having survived so much. They said that if she would help them, by keeping panthers away from their camp while they were away, and preparing the granola and kombucha each morning, as well as acting as interlocutor between the hippies and the raccoons, then Platilocks would be able to keep busy while she stayed with them, as they didn't want her to get bored while she figured out what she wanted to achieve with her life, which was her business and nobody else's, least of all some washed up word-slinger.

Meanwhile, back at the family home: "Mirror mirror on the wall, who is the hottest of them all?" The magic mirror, unsure what it had done in its previous existence to deserve this, but thoroughly repentant of it, replied, "Lady you're peak physical attractiveness, but perhaps hotness is about more than looks, and Platilocks has depth to her. She's still alive with seven progressive gender-non conformers. The Evil Stepmother at this became apoplectic once more, which in concert with the amount of salt she'd eaten just previously couldn't be great for her blood pressure. The father, fortunately, was spared her wrath as he was teaching the twins to swim in the river, a wrath which while perhaps incorrectly founded, was nevertheless accurately applied.

The Evil Stepmother made her way out through the forest, being careful not to trespass on any other panthers' territory as she wandered, crossing the seven mountains, and ultimately finding Platilocks and the hippie camp. The hippies were busy in the orchard, and Platilocks had finished preparing the morrow's granola. She was busily tucking into a book she'd found called the Bodok Thodol, which she'd found particularly illuminating in the light of her present circumstances. She was broken from her reflection, however, by a harsh call. There stood a biker woman, complete with leathers, albeit lacking a motorbike. Platilocks wondered what had become of it?

“Say doll, do you fancy some top-shelf bud? I’ve got the best quality anywhere west of Nelson”. The hippies had been smoking through rather more of the stash than they had meant to, and it would be a while until the local grow that the hippies tended provided a fresh crop yield. “We might be interested”, Platilocks demurred, “But I’d need to sample some first to ensure the terpene balance is right”. The Evil Stepmother purred blackly that nothing could be more natural, and proffered a thin cone, neatly twisted at one end, with a paper cylinder in the other, finer end. Platilocks lit up, but as soon as the laced bud taken a cherry-ember and released a thin wisp of smoke into Platilocks’s unsuspecting lungs, she felt reality slip away and fell convulsing senselessly on the gravel of the campsite. The Evil Stepmother left her for dead.

It wasn’t long before the shadows began to lengthen, and the hippies returned to the campsite (raccoon involvement possibly having been involved), finding Platilocks there in her desperate state, motionless, breath shallow as a wet pavement. They recognized the signs of overdose immediately, and, as they were used to participating in harm-reduction activities, applied the requisite injections of naloxone to counteract the poison. Soon Platilocks had recovered herself, being possessed, as she was, with a hardy and resilient constitution, when it came down to it. She informed the hippies of what had happened, gesturing to the fallen cone as evidence.

The hippies immediately wrapped the cone in tissue paper and swore to dispose of it in a proper receptacle to ensure no further harm might come of it. They also informed Platilocks that there could be no doubt—the Evil Stepmother had arrived disguised as the biker woman, seeking to end Platilocks’s aesthetic dominance. They expressed to Platilocks the importance of remaining dubious of individuals of unknown progeny, especially those offering such easily perverted goods. Panthers, they intimated, came in many different shapes and sizes.

Upon her return to the family home, the Evil Stepmother made once more for the magic mirror: “Mirror mirror on the wall, who is the hottest of them all?” She received the terse reply, “You’re thick where it matters, and thin where it does not. Platilocks’s dose fatal was not. She’s focused on herself and that’s way hot”. At which point the Evil Stepmother resumed her apoplexy, with a face like thunder and a blood pressure like hydraulics. She decided on a new, better plan, and was able to work to prepare the devices she would need unimpeded, as the father was out with the twins shopping for clothes.

The Evil Stepmother crossed the seven mountains once more, very pleased with what the exercise must be doing for her figure, and made it to the hippie camp. She had adorned herself with various bangles, set her hair into messy dreadlocks, and sported a loose tie-dye shirt over parachute pants. She saw Platilocks, who by this point had finished the Bodok Thodol, and was working her way through the Kybalion, in between meditation exercises. “Like, hi, um, do you... like, I have, this would be so cute on you, I, like, think”. The Evil Stepmother held up a hemp hoodie in a red, green, and yellow colour way. Platilocks thought it did look very cozy and warm, while rendering any questions as to her position

on prohibition entirely moot.

Figuring that a hippie, like those of the tribe she was staying with, would be a safe individual to trade with, Platilocks let her guard down, and consented to try on the hoodie and determine if it really was as ruggedly comfortable as it appeared. No sooner had the hoodie slipped down over her diminutive shoulders, but the poisons in the fibers took effect, and Platilocks once more felt her world spinning. “Bother”, she said while tumbling to the gravel. The Evil Stepmother, content that this time she was guaranteed of victory in the male gaze, as the poison had come with an exchange policy if it was ineffective, returned to the family home, where she found the father reading the twins bedtime stories.

The hippies, however, were Johnny on the spot again, as by now they suspected an ongoing campaign on the part of the Evil Stepmother, and wanted to support their friend Platilocks as best they could. It was a good thing they arrived so soon, as the poison’s exchange guarantee was predicated on the assumption that the poison was absorbed orally rather than dermatically, which prevented Platilocks’s being utterly undone. They removed the hoodie from Platilocks’s blessed form, being careful to handle her only as much as was needed to remove the hoodie, and even then with the utmost of respect, aware as they were of all she’d been through, even if it didn’t seem as if she was.

Platilocks ultimately revived herself, and recounted what had gone on while the hippies had been tending the organic cherries in the orchard. The hippies chid Platilocks gently as it had most undoubtedly been the Evil Stepmother once more, and Platilocks could under no circumstances trust anyone who approached the camp when the hippies were not there, regardless of how much tie dye the individual was sporting. The Evil Stepmother was wily, and would stoop as low as she had to to prove that she was the most conventionally desirable lady around, whether anybody actually wanted to be with her or not.

Back at the family house: “Mirror mirror on the wall, who is the hottest of them all?” The Evil Stepmother was really committed to being hot, even while having already a husband and apparently being eminently pleased with him. “You know what I find hot?” The mirror returned. “I find it hot when people use their magic to help others, rather than getting involved in some existential sex appeal pageant. Speaking of which, she’s still alive; go get your poison refund”. That is exactly what the Evil Stepmother did, apoplectically, which made a very bad morning for the apothecary clerk on duty. The father, for his part, was helping the twins with gymnastics training, which gave the Evil Stepmother all the resources she needed for her final lethal sallying forth.

The Evil Stepmother made her way to the hippie camp, crossing the seven mountains and thinking that someone really ought to get a bus service along the route already. She arrived at the camp while the hippies were away in the orchard, and Platilocks put down her copy of Mashaf Res, welcoming the Evil Stepmother with open arms, because the Evil Stepmother had disguised herself as Platilocks’s father. “I am so glad to have found you, Platilocks. I have missed

your company terribly”, the Evil Stepmother lied, “And often thought of you warmly. I am worried that you might grow bony if you only live on this granola, and have brought you a cheese sandwich to keep you in the right shape”.

“Thank you so very much father, but even faced with someone as reliably good as you are, I mustn’t take anything, for fear it is the Evil Stepmother, not to put too fine a point on it, but your wife, who is trying to kill me once more”. Platilocks was sad to let her father down, and hoped he wouldn’t think her too bony. The Evil Stepmother had been ready for this. “I will split the cheese sandwich with you, daughter, so that you can be assured of its goodness”. So-saying, the Evil Stepmother split the cheese sandwich in two, aware as she was, that only one half was poisoned, with the poison the Evil Stepmother had acquired on exchange after the previous draught had been so ineffective. With her worries somewhat assuaged, and not wanting to disappoint her father any more than she already had, Platilocks put the sandwich portion past her lips. “Blast”, was all she had time to say before the gravel raced up to catch her.

Cackling with joy, the Evil Stepmother returned to the family home, where the magic mirror replied to her regular inquiry with “Wow you really killed your stepchild; congratulations on being physically appealing”. Little did the Evil Stepmother realize, but the magic mirror had been doing some caterwauling while it knew the Evil Stepmother was out, and had managed to get the father to find it, telling him that he needed to keep his wife in check because she was on some unhinged quest to kill a young lady just because she pulled off teal better than the Evil Stepmother did. The father had not taken this lightly.

The hippies returned back and found Platilocks dead. They put her in a coffin made of cedar, along with a small rubber duck that Platilocks had seemed to have grown fond of, since she’d found it in the communal sponge-bag, and took her into the organic cherry orchard, where she was to be buried among the cherry trees, which they felt she would appreciate. As the coffin was being carried between the trees and towards the waiting gap in the earth, one of the pall-bearers stumbled on a root, and jostled the coffin, along with its occupant. A chunk of cheese sandwich flew from Platilocks’s mouth, and she gasped out a squeak of life. The hippies fell over each other in their mad dash to hug her while respecting her bodily autonomy, and told her that she was welcome to stay with them and research esoteric spirituality as long as she wished.

Meanwhile, back at the family home, the father had decided that his wife really was the fairest of them all on the outside, but couldn’t be trusted on the inside. Accordingly, he kept her chained inside the house, and would not suffer her to be outside it. He was careful to raise the twins with the utmost tact and delicacy, and did his best to manage his darker instincts by funnelling them into forms where the pain would be minimized. The Evil Stepmother ultimately learned to appreciate the protection of the family home, and appreciated not needing agency any more. She’d seen where that got her.

‘Saint Germain and the Panther’ There once was a panther which dwelt along

the misty slopes of a mountain range, and ever since the delapidation of the communication system warning of its approach, the village in the area had needs paid tribute to the panther, in order to keep it from rampaging through the village. The panther was fearsome, and breathed violet flames which were agonizing to endure even for a moment. Striking at random, it would destroy anything in its path, without fear of retribution from the villagers who were busy pointing fingers at each other for the lapses in village security.

The panther had been getting hungrier and hungrier as the villagers fed it, and soon the village had run out of sheep, pigs, and remarkably literarily adroit cows with which to assuage the panther's hunger. They tried offering the panther their plat jewelry, which distracted the big cat momentarily with the shininess thereof, but which ultimately was insufficient to divert the panther's hunger. So they had to begin feeding the panther people, which was when the finger pointing really came in handy, as by that point the villagers had established a rigid hierarchy of blame based upon who had been comparatively responsible for the lapses in village security.

Soon, there were few left standing in the village, and tumbleweeds blew across what had once been bustling thoroughfares. The panther was more ravenous than it had ever been before, and there was little recourse but to offer the panther further food, for the betterment of the few who remained. A young woman named Sal was sent to satisfy the panther's appetite, and she wandered along the path to the panther's lair as she was entreated to do, her thoughts heavy, hoping only that by her sacrifice she would be able to prevent the panther's growing hungry once more for as long as possible.

Now, there was, wandering, a knight by the name of Saint Germain, who had happened upon the village upon the slopes through some stroke of fate, having ridden a dragon into the area, just to check if they'd any chivalrous deeds or quests in needs of nobly completing. He found Sal, weeping as she went to meet the panther, and asked her why she wept. "I must fill the panther's belly", she replied. He, smelling valour in the air, impressed upon her the importance of her not demeaning herself so far, as he himself would go in her stead. She readily assented to this proposition, and could soon be seen high-tailing it whence she came.

Saint Germain sallied forth along the path, deeper into the forest, and towards the panther's lair. He toted a titanium shield with the omega and a central dot emblazoned thereupon, and his blade was of ensorcelled plat, and rested at the end of a titanium pole. His mail was an advanced steel alloy, and so finely joined plate-to-plate that he moved without restriction; and shone from helm, to boot. He knew he was venturing closer to the panther's lair by the pungent odour of disintegrating flesh mingling with brimstone, and the gradually increasing number of bones he passed on his way. Some of them had been broken in half, and the marrow sucked. When he came to the sheer face of a cliff, with the mountain hanging overhead, he wondered if perhaps he had made a wrong turn yonder, then saw the split in the stone.

A cave opening was visible, veering down sharply from the level ground towards where Saint Germain knew not. He pondered his options momentarily, but then that distinctly pheromonal flavour of chivalry once more wafted over our hero, and he was drawn onward into the lair proper. As he entered and began descending the perilous slope, the light swiftly sunk to nil, and the crunch of bones beneath his steel boots echoed around the narrow passageway. The chirping of birds and rustle of trees in the wind from the forest beyond faded then was gone, and yet soon, there replaced it a resonant thrum. Whether 'twas growl, or purr, Saint Germain knew not.

He veered about a bend, and the noise ceased with alarming immediacy. Instead, about the chamber a light chuckling tapped back and forth on the walls, and for all his training at Knightly Academy, Saint Germain was afraid, but he remembered his knightly training. Knees all a-knock, he called out towards where he thought the noise was emanating from, "Hey-ho panther, come out and rationalize your extraction from this rural subsistence community!" He heard only a *shing* of claws extending in response, and knew that the panther was loath to discuss the mercurial ethics of its deeds.

'Twas not the hour for economic debates; 'twas the hour for battle. Saint Germain readied his tower shield with the nifty heraldry on it, gripping the plat-bladed—titanium-handled spear by his left hip, and advancing whistling a wee martial ditty he'd learned at the Academy. He heard a pad ahead, which fell with the grace of a dancer and the weight of a mountain on the cavern floor. All of a sudden, Saint Germain was wreathed in violet flame, as the panther spewed forth billows of pyre. His shield repelled the worst of the torrent, but his steel boots were rather toastier than usual, and he mourned the loss of a toe or two.

The opening salvo having been insufficient to repel its adversary, the panther took advantage of Saint Germain's momentary dazzle from the flame's brightness suddenly disappearing. As Saint Germain's eyes struggled to readjust to the inky dark, the panther pounced upon him. Saint Germain, however, had remembered his knightly training, and maintained his shield's upright position, with his tremulous but controlled spear thrust over the top of it, in case of any pantheric pouncing. This held him in excellent stead. While he was bowled back by the panther's pounce, he was able to pierce the panther's breast in the process.

Saint Germain found himself supine and struggling with the thrashing panther which was crushing the life from him. He couldn't breathe, but as the panther crushed harder on top of him, seeking to squeeze the life from his pinned form, the spear pierced deeper in the panther, and Saint Germain could feel the panther's hot blood beginning to gush onto him. Aware of what he had to do if he wanted to walk out of the cave ever again, and with deep regret at the necessity, Saint Germain twisted the spear. He felt the panther thrash and writhe, and the howling roar it loosed shook the cave walls.

The panther tried to crush Saint Germain, but the knight could feel the panther's strength waning. Soon, the pressure on him began to subside, and he began to draw greater breath. This was all the impetus he needed. Dissociating his sense of pity, Saint Germain became automatic, and ignored the whimpers and squeals as the panther backed away, he advanced robotically, thrusting his spear and mentally glossing the piteous cries which came at each thrust. When the panther finally stopped moving, Saint Germain removed its head, to tender to the townspeople as a token of their safety.

Saint Germain then eviscerated the panther's fuel organ system, and began spreading the pungent biofuel around the cave system. He placed what bones he could from outside the cave within the system, and upon exiting the cave for the second time, used his spear to create a spark, and ignite the cave system. Saint Germain only just ducked in time when a ball of violet fire leapt from the cave opening and up towards the heavens. The resulting shock caused a minor cave-in, and the entrance to the cave system in the rock face was closed forevermore.

Upon returning to the village, Saint Germain found Sal, and provided her the panther's head as a token of her safety. She was immensely grateful. "You have done much, brave knight, and I would be pleased to reward you with my hand in marriage, for far from being just any old wench, I am in fact the local magistrate's daughter", she said to him. He impressed upon her the importance of emotional compatibility and intellectual engagement over material comforts and completion of arbitrary tally-cards for locating proper mates, besides which, he'd grown to enjoy his solitude. Saint Germain went to scrub the blue blood from his armour, hail a dragon, and see what was over the next mountain.

'Morals' Jill was a resourceful young lady, who had grown up on her parents farm, where they kept pigs who wallowed in misery, constantly discussing the mistakes that had led them there, and chickens who clucked, and had a single anorexic cow who'd long ago ceased to produce milk and by now produced only cynical comments on the state of the dairy industry as a whole. A few fields of soybeans, wheat, and a small cranberry bog were all also boasted by the family, and these had the good sense to largely keep quiet.

Despite these ample resources, which all but guaranteed Jill's comfort indefinitely, so long as pigs reproduced and cranberries could be relied upon to sprout, Jill felt that something lacked from her day-to-day comings and goings. The routine was safe, and safety was to be adored, but sometimes she found herself absent-mindedly wondering what more there was. It was difficult to express this to her parents however, as they were salt of the earth, and found any more than three syllables in close quarters suspect.

Her parents would hear nothing of 'nonsense', as they repeatedly told her, and suggested that she muck the sty whenever the topic invariably resurfaced around the dinner table. The pigs bemoaning of their poor prospects was always enough to ground Jill back in the present pressures, primarily familial. Jill felt herself

stymied, and one day represented her desires more directly than she'd done so heretofore to her parents.

"Mother, Father, please, can't you understand that all I want is to be able to know of the world, and to be follow its quirks and oddities?" Jill asked with a tremble in her voice. Her parents, Mother and Father both, were, despite their best efforts, moved by her persistence in the face of their resolution, and they noted her evident conviction.

"What is it you would know?" Asked Jill's mother, after a moment's deliberation. "Your father and I are possessed of worldly knowledge enough, as we can butcher swine and reap wheat." But this was insufficient for Jill's ambitions, and she informed them as much.

"I would learn the reason that water is wet, my blessed parents," she said, having tussled with the question for quite some time. The parents reflected, and then agreed that truly they were ignorant of what made water wet, and that thus Jill would have to go out and seek for the answer more widely. She began by canvassing the creatures of the farmyard.

"The question you ask, as it pertains quite directly to milk, is one I may shed some limited light on," the cow conceded. "But woefully ignorant am I of such sacred wisdom, all that I may tell you is that such knowledge cannot be received via regular speech, but rather is always hidden plainly, in the guise of a story." The cow carefully chewed cud while so-saying.

"A story is a start!" Cried Jill. "Which story is it that contains this most venerable of wisdoms?" She thought that if only she could depart imminently she would be able to make it to the library in time for closing and take out a work likely to contain the tale, whatever it may be.

But the cow could only sadly shake her horns. "If I knew which story held such wisdom, I would tell you, but all I know is what I've told, and even that I have only been able to piece together myself from threads of comments heard in passing. There may be those better placed than I to answer your inquiry, but I know of none here."

The pigs were considerably less useful, and insisted on commenting at length on the insufficiency of their knowledge, and how it only stemmed from their own individual sloth in each case, which prevented their advancing in the world. Summarily brought down from the buzz that the cow had provided, Jill decided that the story would need to be sought elsewhere in the world, beyond the regions of the farm, and even perhaps the county, where she'd never ventured before.

Jill walked to the library and was greeted there by an orangutang with a benevolent expression, a bag of peanuts in one hand, and a small duck-shaped paperweight preventing a manuscripts, blowing away. The orangutang impressed upon her that the story she sought was not to be found in the library at this time, but that she would be more than welcome to check back later on the

offchance it were committed to paper and brought to the librarian's attention. This was all expressed in a single syllable, repeated at varying pitches.

So on Jill wandered, heading from out of town into the woods which nestled along the valley of the mountains. She had set out with a direction in mind, following the setting sun and diligently keeping to the path laid out before her as best she could, but it grew overgrown, and what had at first appeared a channel through which she might seek the answer, grew snarled with brambles. Thorns tore at her sky-blue dress, and she wept with frustration.

It was then that she smelt something, faint amidst the dominant pine fragrance, yet unmistakeable, it was the odour of burning hair, mingling confusingly with that of confectionary. Jill paused, and identifying the direction the smells were wafting from, pushed aside the scraggly limbs of a thicket and saw, in a clearing, a small cottage constructed entirely of candy and cake.

Well aware of precedent, Jill took a long hard look at the cottage, and considered the peril she might now find herself in, but considering stories were what she was after, and here was one she recognized, she went over to the door, which was made of marzipan, and knocked with the delicacy of one aware of almond paste's structural integrity.

"No!" Came the immediate reply. "I am not interested in worshipping with you this Sunday! I have already been immensely clear about my Wiccan beliefs and your inability to respect such a clear boundary is bordering on the—" and the door opened revealing a hunched yet spry looking woman in a black robe and pointy black hat. "Oh hello dearie, fancy you coming to see a lonely old lady like me. Lawks!"

Behind the witch was a truly immense oven, with a glass plate on the front of it. Four scorched handprints could be seen on the glass plate. There was a lock on the oven door. While the smell of burnt hair was the most immediately arresting of the odours coming from this oven, there was also, now Jill was inside, the faintest hint of rosemary and thyme as well.

"I have come seeking a story, that will tell me why water is wet." Jill puffed out her chest as she said so, trying to portray a woman as confident in herself as could be, but all the while aware that her slight perspiration might give her away. The witch raised a single eyebrow ever so slowly.

"That's a funny thing for a fine young lady like you to ask about. But I tell you what, you set the table and carve the meat and I will tell you what I know of water's wetness, or rather, of the story which shows you how wet water is." The witch offered Jill a large fork and a carving knife. "The roast will be done in a few moments."

Jill dutifully carved dinner, with all the skill and dexterity that time on the farm had taught her, and soon the witch was happily pickling the cooked meat and had pulled out a large pot in which to stew the bones. Having upheld her side of the bargain, Jill again represented her case to the witch.

“The story you seek is a brief one, but succinct in its wisdom.” The witch carefully screwed the lid on a jar and picked up a marker to write the date on the jar. “And it must be told backwards by the light of a blue blood moon for the wisdom to truly take effect.”

“But what is the story?” Asked Jill. She was busily taking the jars the witch filled and placing them in the fridge. There were other things in the fridge; Jill blocked them out.

“Why my dear,” the witch’s voice took on a note of bemused fascination. “It’s this one, of course.”